



◀ THE BATTLE OF YORKTOWN

The final battle of the American Revolutionary War, in 1781, set American troops and their French allies against British redcoats. Although the Americans made fun of the formality of the British, they created their own disciplined, uniformed army to fight the war.

KEY EVENTS

1700–1800

- **c.1700** European armies abandon the pike and adopt the socket bayonet, which fits over the barrel of a flintlock musket.
- **1713–40** By employing draconian punishments, King Frederick William I of Prussia transforms the Prussian army into Europe's most rigorously disciplined military force.
- **1740s** Ramrods made of iron, rather than wood, and cartridges (paper containers that combine both ball and powder) are introduced. These innovations improve the speed of musket loading – and also rates of fire.
- **1744** Frederick the Great of Prussia, the son of Frederick William I, recruits Jäger (huntsmen) as light rifle-armed troops in the Prussian army.
- **1775** American commander-in-chief George Washington creates the Continental Army, a European-style uniformed force armed with muskets, to fight against the British during the American War of Independence.
- **1776** General Jean Baptiste de Gribeauval initiates a major reform of French artillery, introducing standardized sizes and lighter gun carriages to improve mobility.

“If my soldiers were to begin to think, not one would remain in the army”

FREDERICK THE GREAT (FREDERICK II, KING OF PRUSSIA), c.18TH CENTURY